

States **WEST BENGAL**

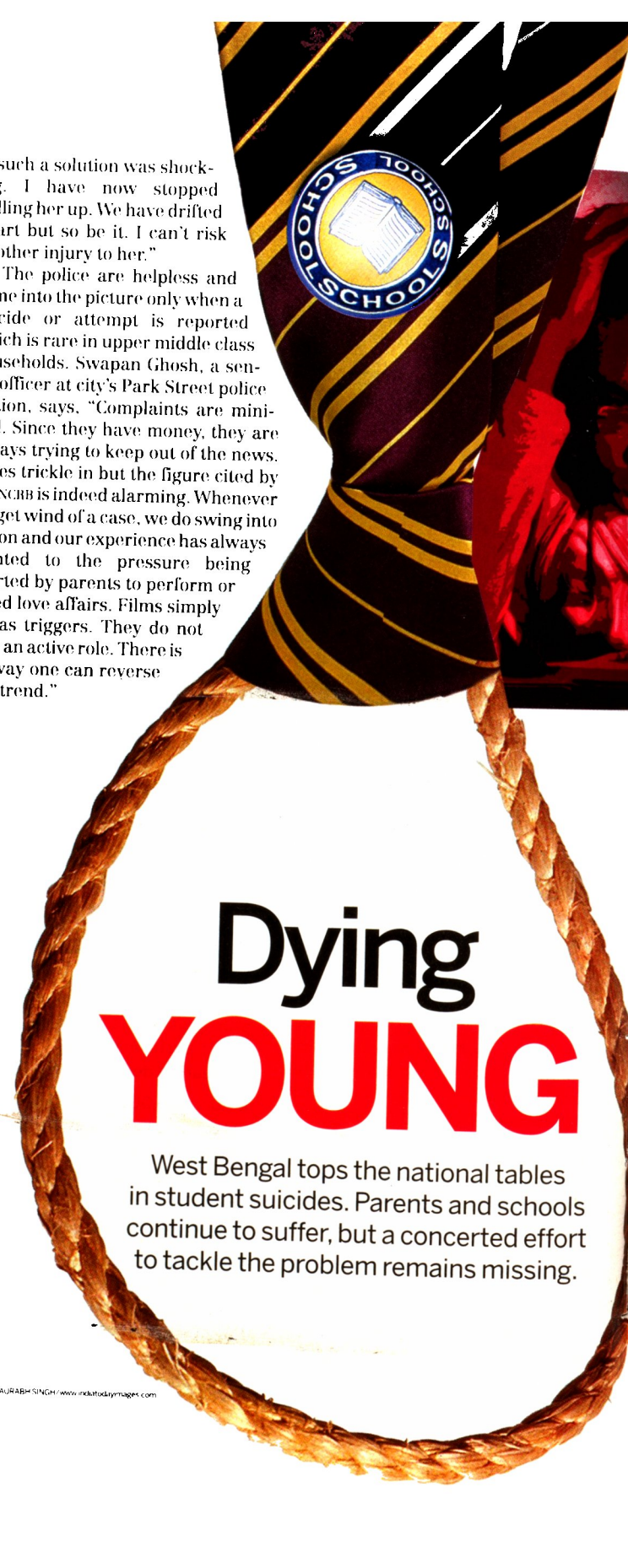
By Abhijit Dasgupta

The pressure is just killing, quite literally. In just released statistics from the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB), West Bengal has for the third consecutive year earned the dubious distinction of being the state with the largest number of students committing suicide. There is some consolation in the fact that the figure which stands at 940 for the year 2008 has registered a dip after being on the rise for the last two years. The state, however, is ill-prepared to tackle this menace; there's not enough infrastructure to handle what is a significant problem. Doctors point an accusing finger at indifferent parents putting too much pressure on their children to perform, especially after the debate over the death of 18-year-old Class XII student Samata Maloo in Kolkata recently. The police had conclusively proved that Maloo had committed suicide. Clinical psychologist Dr Anupam Das, who is associated with the NGO, Mon Foundation, says that parental pressure is one obvious cause but gives it a generational twist: "The aspiration level of those who grew up in the 1970s and '80s were stymied when they began their own careers because of the massive unemployment crisis then. Now with opportunities opening up, they want to live their lives through their children. This is not only unfair but critically burdensome for the children. Parents ought to understand and not create unnecessary pressure on their children."

Sanjoy Adhikari, a bank officer, learnt it the hard way. Late last year, his only daughter, Neel (name changed), slashed her wrists shortly after watching a film on the Internet. With her higher secondary examinations around the corner, she was admonished by her father that 2 a.m. was not the correct time to watch a Shah Rukh Khan movie. Adhikari recalls: "She simply looked at me, darted inside the bathroom and slashed her wrists with a blade. The injuries were minor but the very fact that my daughter could have thought

of such a solution was shocking. I have now stopped pulling her up. We have drifted apart but so be it. I can't risk another injury to her."

The police are helpless and come into the picture only when a suicide or attempt is reported which is rare in upper middle class households. Swapan Ghosh, a senior officer at city's Park Street police station, says, "Complaints are minimal. Since they have money, they are always trying to keep out of the news. Cases trickle in but the figure cited by the NCRB is indeed alarming. Whenever we get wind of a case, we do swing into action and our experience has always pointed to the pressure being exerted by parents to perform or failed love affairs. Films simply act as triggers. They do not play an active role. There is no way one can reverse this trend."



Dying YOUNG

West Bengal tops the national tables in student suicides. Parents and schools continue to suffer, but a concerted effort to tackle the problem remains missing.

Illustration: SAURABH SINGH/www.indiatodaymag.com